

Waste Audit Report

Building(s):	NR/Forestry	Collection Period:	Feb 17 - 23, 2025
Waste Stream:	Landfill	Audited By:	Office of Sustainability

Purpose: Waste audits are a great way to understand what waste is produced and where. It gives us a better idea of what is being thrown out, how much, and what common contaminants persist (e.g., recyclable materials that are ending up in the landfill bin). We can use the results from the audit to better inform building occupants and to improve our waste collection systems.

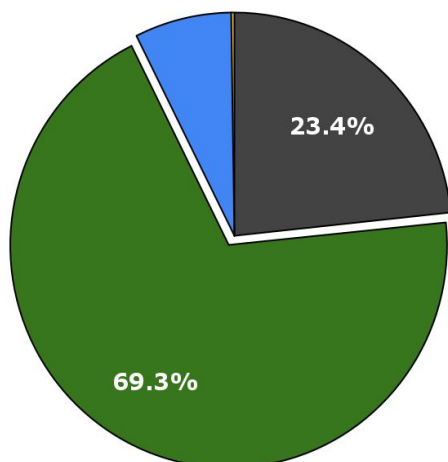
Description: The Office of Sustainability (OS) conducted an audit of the landfill dumpster shared by the Natural Resources (NR) and Forestry buildings. Material from the dumpster was collected throughout the collection period and then sorted, categorized and weighed. The audit team sorted waste according to the following categories:

- **Landfill:** solid waste items that cannot be recycled or composted
- **Recycling:** mixed recycling items like bottles, cans, paper, cardboard and plastic containers
- **Compost:** includes food, paper towels, fiber-based food service ware that is locally compostable
- **Universal Waste:** electronics, batteries and other U-Waste items that can be recycled
- **Hazardous Waste:** chemicals, biohazards and other items that cannot be disposed of in landfill

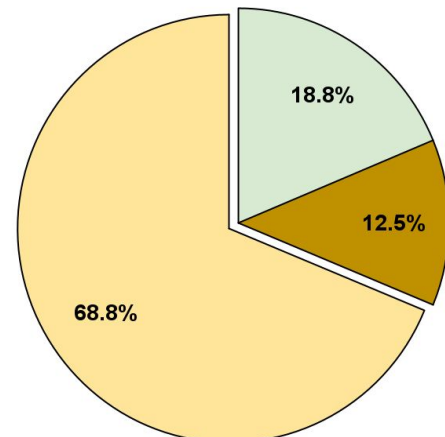
Results: The audit team also walked through the buildings to assess the bins, signage and other factors that may contribute to waste generation and disposal patterns as seen in the landfill dumpster. Key findings are summarized below:

- Used paper towels, a compostable item, significantly exceed all other items by weight and by volume
- Although paper towel compost bins are available in the restrooms, it appears that Custodial Services may be depositing all used paper towels into the landfill dumpster
- Rolls of unused paper towels (10-20% of a full roll) with a plastic cap were found in the dumpster
- Though only 0.2% of total weight, batteries are highly toxic and illegal to put in the landfill. There is also an ECycler bin in NR for battery recycling.
- Plastic bags used by Custodial Services comprised ~5% by volume of audited material.

Percent by Weight (Total)



% Compost that is Paper Towels



● Landfill ● Compost ● Recycling ● U-Waste

● Food ● Compostable Packaging ● Paper Towels

Recommendations: Based on the building assessments and the waste audit of the landfill dumpster, the audit team has the following recommendations:

- Review collection and disposal practices with custodians servicing the buildings. In particular, provide guidance on paper towel composting, including removal (when possible) of any contaminants in the paper towel stream.
- Place one or more lockable wheeled carts for paper towel compost alongside the dumpsters. Coordinate with Refuse & Recycling to regularly empty the wheeled carts into the composting vessel.
- Avoid throwing out paper towel rolls that still have usable paper on the roll. Not only is this a waste of money, it adds to the generation of methane in landfills, a potent greenhouse gas.
- Empty paper towel rolls should be recycled. Remove the plastic cap on the paper towel roll before recycling the roll. If the plastic cap cannot be reused, recycle it.
- NR second floor at the top of the stairs: replace the missing landfill sign on the multi-hole bin.
- NR 1st floor ECycler: put a E-Waste/U-Waste Recycling sign in a transparent sign holder mounted to the top of the ECycler. This can help clarify the purpose of the bin.
- NR and Forestry: The universal standard is to have recycling on the right hand side and landfill on the left, however it's the opposite for the hallway bins in these buildings. We recommend you flip the bins around and relabel accordingly.
- NR and Forestry: To reduce contamination in hallway bins, mount "Recycle" and "Landfill" infographic signs above the multi-hole bins. See picture below.
- Send building occupants the audit results and Waste & Recycling Guides. Ask for their help to reduce contamination and waste.
- Send students commonly using Forestry and NR buildings (e.g., ESM, Forestry, Fire & Rangeland Mgmt majors) the Waste & Recycling Guides and ask for their help to reduce contamination and waste.



*Found in the landfill dumpster:
Paper towel roll, still with ~15% of
its paper towels, with plastic cap*



*Put infographic Recycle and
Landfill signs above the hallway
bins*



*Send waste and recycling guides to
students, faculty and staff using NR
and Forestry buildings.*

For More Information: To request a presentation of the audit results, or to provide additional feedback, email mpk9@humboldt.edu. For more information on Cal Poly Humboldt's waste reduction initiatives, go to <https://www.humboldt.edu/sustainable-campus/campus-operations/waste-reduction>.